this architecture “produces interoperable, modular systems that are easier to use and maintain” (http://mng.bz/lJgR), while in the background, Simple Object Access Protocol (SOAP) became its de facto implementation.

To shed light on the characteristics of this architecture, SOA attempts to solve three problem dimensions: complexity, which increases as a system reaches the top of an organization, while usability for end users decreases; stability, because a platform must be flexible to create what different users need, but it must be stable as a whole and provide the glue for its parts; and last, but definitely not least, data sharing. Data must be able to be consumed but also secured. Not everyone should have access to everything. And this problem of data discovery and use is exacerbated not only by data within the organization but also by data sent to and from outside the organization. Thanks to the invention of the World Wide Web in recent decades, this door to the outside world has been opened wider than ever.

The idea of interoperability is almost ubiquitous in SOA, where abstractions in departmental applications enable the flow of valuable information. There are echoes here of EAI and, of course, middleware. Figure B.3 shows an SOA representation from this era.